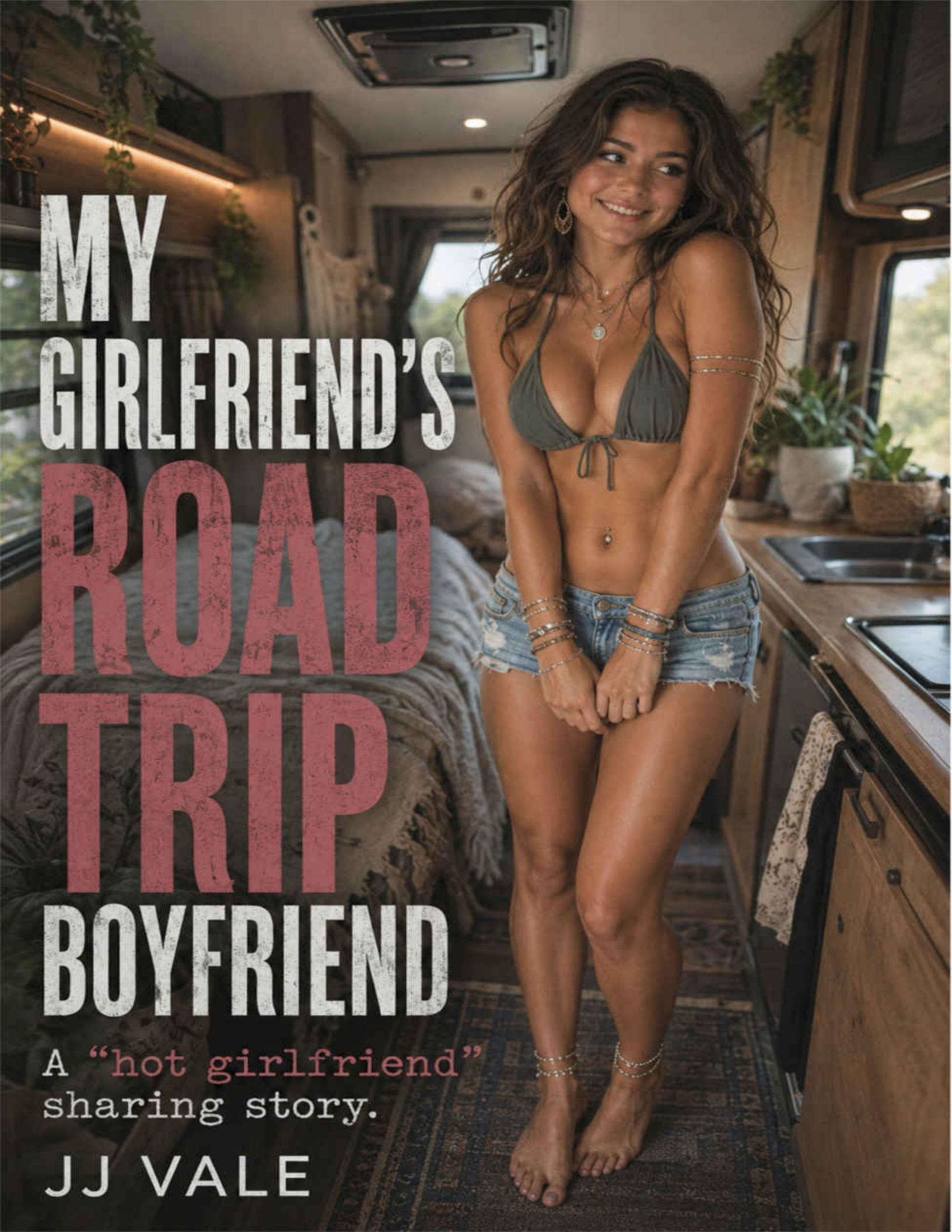


A woman with long, wavy brown hair is smiling and posing in a camper van. She is wearing a dark green halter-neck bikini top, a belly button ring, and denim shorts. She has multiple bracelets on both wrists and anklets on both ankles. The camper van interior features wooden paneling, a kitchen counter with a sink and stove, and a bed in the background.

MY GIRLFRIEND'S ROAD TRIP BOYFRIEND

A “hot girlfriend”
sharing story.

JJ VALE

My Girlfriend's Roadtrip Boyfriend

A "hot girlfriend" sharing story

JJ Vale

PMI

The Winnebago's chrome bumper caught the afternoon sun like a signal mirror as Ashley and I turned into Cruz's driveway. She leaned forward in the passenger seat, her hand bracing against the dashboard.

"That's the RV?" she asked.

"That's her," I said, pulling my truck to a stop beside Cruz's garage.

The thing was magnificent. Twenty-eight feet of restored 1986 Chieftain, its white and tan exterior gleaming from what had to be a fresh wax job. Cruz had spent the last eighteen months bringing it back from the dead, and I'd spent most weekends over the past six months helping him gut the interior and rebuild it from the frame up.

Cruz emerged from his front door before I'd even killed the engine, grinning like he'd just won the lottery. He wore his usual weekend uniform: faded Carhartt work pants and a brewery t-shirt, this one from some craft place in Portland we'd hit last summer.

"You made it!" He jogged down the steps and headed straight for Ashley's side of the truck. "You must be Ashley. Reid's told me absolutely nothing about you, which means he's serious."

Ashley laughed and accepted his handshake through the open window. "He mentioned you built this yourself?"

"Rebuilt. Big difference." Cruz stepped back as we climbed out. "The bones were solid, but everything else was trashed. Water damage, mice, the works. Come on, I'll show you what we did."

The RV's door opened with a satisfying mechanical click, the kind that spoke of proper alignment and fresh weather stripping. Cruz had replaced all the seals two months ago, and we'd spent an entire Saturday making sure every edge sat flush.

Inside, the smell of new upholstery mixed with lemon wood polish. The transformation still caught me off guard. I'd seen it in stages, knew every inch of the work, but standing here with the afternoon light streaming through the windows, it felt like stepping into a different vehicle entirely.

"Original cabinets," Cruz said, running his hand along the honey-colored wood that lined the galley. "We stripped them down to bare wood, fixed all the joinery, then refinished them with tung oil. Took forever."

"Three coats," I added. "Cruz insisted on hand-rubbing every surface."

"Because that's how you do it right." He opened one of the overhead compartments. "New piano hinges on everything. The originals were shot."

Ashley moved through the space slowly, taking it in. The kitchenette occupied the right side, compact but functional. Stainless steel sink, two-burner propane stove, a surprisingly spacious refrigerator that Cruz had upgraded to a newer model that could run on either propane or electric.

"We rewired the whole electrical system," I said, pointing to the outlets positioned at regular intervals along the walls. "Updated it to modern code, added USB ports, upgraded the battery bank."

"Solar panels on the roof," Cruz added. "Four hundred watts. We can run everything indefinitely as long as we're not running the air conditioning constantly."

The dinette booth sat behind the driver's seat, upholstered in a dark gray fabric that managed to look both durable and comfortable. Cruz had fabricated the table himself from a piece of walnut he'd found at a salvage yard, the grain running in rich, dark streams across its surface.

"This converts to two beds," he said, demonstrating how the table lowered to meet the seat cushions. "We're going to have to wrestle over the back bedroom." We all chuckled at what that could mean.

He led us toward the rear, past the bathroom that took up the right side of the narrow hallway. The shower was small but serviceable, the toilet a newer composting model that Cruz had installed after extensive research into off-grid options.

The bedroom occupied the entire back end of the RV. A queen-sized mattress dominated the space, covered in a simple gray comforter. Storage compartments lined the walls above and below, and a small window on each side let in cross-ventilation.

"Memory foam," Cruz said, slapping the mattress. "Because I'm not a monster. The original mattress was basically a crime scene."

Ashley sat on the edge, testing it. "This is actually comfortable."

"Everything works," Cruz said. "Heat, AC, hot water, all of it. We pressure-tested the water system last week, replaced the water heater, put in a new water pump. The holding tanks are clean. I even got the original radio

working, though I also installed a Bluetooth receiver because I'm not stuck in 1986."

I walked to the driver's seat and ran my hand over the steering wheel. We'd replaced it along with most of the dashboard components, keeping the original aesthetic but upgrading the functionality. The instrument cluster glowed softly, new LED bulbs behind the old-style gauges.

"How does she drive?" Ashley asked.

"Like a boat," Cruz and I said simultaneously, then laughed.

"You get used to it," I added. "Wide turns, long stopping distance, but the engine runs smooth. We rebuilt the carburetor, new plugs, new belts, fresh fluids."

"I took her up to the mountains two weeks ago," Cruz said. "She handled the grades fine. Gets about eight miles per gallon, which is terrible by modern standards but amazing for a vehicle this old and this heavy."

Ashley completed another circuit of the interior, opening cabinets, testing the stove knobs, running water in the sink. "You guys really did all this?"

"Most of it," I said. "We hired out the propane certification and the roof AC installation, but everything else was us."

"Months of weekends," Cruz said. "But worth it. She's ready for anything now."

We spent another twenty minutes going over details. Cruz showed Ashley how to operate the awning, explained the fresh water and gray water systems, demonstrated the furnace and the water heater controls. He'd printed out a laminated instruction sheet for everything and stuck it inside one of the kitchen cabinets.

Finally, we headed back to my truck to grab our bags. I'd packed light: a duffel with clothes, a smaller bag with toiletries and books, my camera bag. Ashley had a rolling suitcase and a backpack, both looking efficiently packed.

"I'll grab the cooler from the garage," Cruz said. "Already loaded it this morning. Beer, sandwich stuff, the basics."

We formed a chain, passing bags through the RV's door and finding spots for everything in the various storage compartments. Ashley's suitcase fit in the bedroom's lower cabinet, my duffel in the overhead. The cooler went into the space beside the refrigerator, perfectly sized like Cruz had measured for it.

"Keys," Cruz said, tossing them to me. They landed in my palm with a solid weight, attached to a keychain in the shape of a tiny Winnebago.

I knew already, this was going to be an awesome road trip.

The highway stretched ahead through farmland and scattered pine forests, the Winnebago's engine maintaining a steady rumble beneath our conversation. Cruz had taken the first driving shift, which left Ashley and me to figure out where we were actually going.

"So we have no plan whatsoever," Ashley said, settling into the dinette booth across from me as I pulled out my tablet.

"We have a direction," I said. "North."

"That's half a compass, not a plan."

Cruz called back from the driver's seat, "There's a state park about two hours up that has RV camping. We could hit that for tonight, then figure out the rest as we go."

I pulled up the map application and zoomed out to show the full scope of options. The Pacific Northwest sprawled across the screen in topographic detail, hundreds of potential stops marked with icons for campgrounds, scenic viewpoints, and trail heads.

"Come look at this," I said to Cruz.

"Kind of busy."

"I'll hold the wheel," Ashley offered.

"That's not how driving works," Cruz said, but he glanced in the oversized rearview mirror, checking the road behind us. "Actually, there's a rest stop in about five miles. We can pull over and do this properly."

We made it to the rest stop and Cruz set the parking brake, then squeezed out from behind the wheel and headed back to where Ashley and I sat. The dinette booth suddenly felt much smaller with three people trying to occupy it.

I scooted over to make room, but the booth was built for two people to sit comfortably or four people to sit miserably. Cruz wedged himself next to Ashley, and we all hunched over the tablet, elbows colliding as we tried to point at different locations.

"This isn't working," Ashley said, laughing as Cruz's elbow jabbed her ribs for the third time.

"We could take turns," I suggested.

"Or you could sit on my lap," Cruz said to Ashley, completely deadpan. "Make some room for the rest of us."

Ashley snorted. "Smooth."

"I'm a practical man. We need space. You're the smallest. Mathematics."

"Is that what you tell all the girls?" Ashley asked, but she was already moving, sliding from her spot and repositioning herself on Cruz's lap like she was settling into a chair. "There. Better?"

"Much," Cruz said. "See? Problem solving."

I pulled the tablet closer, and suddenly we could all see the screen without dislocating shoulders. Ashley leaned forward slightly, her elbows on the table, and Cruz shifted to look over her shoulder.

"We could pretend to be boyfriend and girlfriend," Ashley said suddenly, grinning. "Really sell it. Make Reid uncomfortable."

"I'm already uncomfortable," I said. "This booth wasn't designed for human use."

"No, she's onto something," Cruz said. "We could do the whole thing. Pet names, hand holding, the works."

"You two are insane," I said.

"Babe, he's just jealous," Ashley said to Cruz, her voice dripping with exaggerated sweetness.

Cruz wrapped his arms around her waist like they were posing for a photo. "Obviously. Look at us. We're adorable."

Ashley dissolved into laughter, and Cruz joined her, and I shook my head while trying not to smile.

"Can we please figure out where we're going?" I asked.

"Fine, fine," Ashley said, composing herself. She pointed at the screen. "What about Olympic National Park? I've never been."

"That's a solid choice," Cruz said, leaning closer to look. "Hurricane Ridge, the Hoh Rainforest, the coast. We could spend three or four days there easily."

I zoomed in on the park boundaries. "The problem is campground reservations. Most of the official spots book up months in advance."

"There are dispersed camping areas," Cruz said. "BLM land around the edges. We don't need full hookups. The RV's totally self-contained."

Ashley scrolled through the map, reading names off the screen. "Lake Crescent, Ruby Beach, Rialto Beach. These all look amazing."

"We could do a loop," I said, tracing a rough route with my finger. "Start at Hurricane Ridge, work our way through the interior, then hit the coast on the way back down."

"How long would that take?" Ashley asked.

"Week, maybe?" Cruz said. "Depending on how long we want to stay at each spot."

"We have two weeks total," I said. "We could do Olympic for one week, then swing down the coast for the second week. Hit some of the Oregon spots."

Ashley twisted to look at Cruz. "What do you think, honey?"

"I think you're committing to this bit way harder than necessary, sweetheart," Cruz said.

"I think you two need hobbies," I said.

"This is our hobby," Ashley said. "Being annoying and adorable."

She settled back against Cruz's chest, and they both looked at the tablet with exaggerated focus, like a couple planning their future together. I had to admit, the cramped space actually worked now. We could all see the screen clearly, point at different features, discuss options without constantly shifting positions.

"Okay, serious question," Cruz said. "Do we want to do serious hiking, or are we keeping it casual?"

"Define serious," Ashley said.

"Like, all-day summit attempts versus easy nature walks to waterfalls."

"I'm good for moderate stuff," I said. "Five or six miles with some elevation gain. Nothing that requires technical gear."

"Same," Ashley said. "I didn't pack climbing equipment or anything."

Cruz nodded. "That opens up most of the good trails in Olympic. The rainforest hikes are pretty flat. Hurricane Ridge has some great moderate trails with incredible views."

"What about camping spots?" Ashley asked. "Where do we stay tonight?"

I pulled up a different map layer showing campgrounds and recreation areas. "If we keep driving for another three hours, we could make it to this place near Mount Rainier. It's got water and dump stations, and it's on the way to Olympic."

"Or we could find something closer and have an actual evening," Cruz said. "Not just drive until dark."

"There's a national forest campground about ninety minutes from here," Ashley said, pointing. "Lake Roosevelt. It's right on the water."

I looked up photos on my phone. The campground sat on the shore of a massive reservoir, with designated RV sites spread among pine trees. The

reviews mentioned good sunset views and relatively quiet neighbors.

"This looks perfect for a first night," I said. "Easy to get to, good amenities, scenic."

"Lake Roosevelt it is," Cruz said. "That's our first destination."

Ashley shifted her weight, and Cruz adjusted his arms around her waist. "You two comfortable enough, or should we actually hit the road?" I asked.

"I could stay like this all day," Ashley said. "Cruz makes an excellent chair."

"Sturdy, reliable, occasionally makes weird noises," Cruz added.

"That's the RV, not you," I said.

"Both, actually," Cruz said.

We spent another few minutes finalizing the route, marking potential stops along the way, and downloading offline maps in case we lost cell service. Ashley remained on Cruz's lap the entire time, occasionally making exaggerated romantic gestures that made Cruz laugh and me roll my eyes.

Finally, Cruz patted Ashley's leg. "Alright, off you go. Someone needs to drive this thing."

Ashley slid back to her original spot, and Cruz extracted himself from the booth, stretching his arms overhead.

"I'll take this shift," I said. "You drove the first leg."

"Works for me," Cruz said. "I'll navigate, make sure you don't miss the turnoff."

The rest stop occupied a rectangle of asphalt carved from dense forest, twenty parking spaces arranged in two neat rows with a cinderblock bathroom building at the far end. We'd pulled in behind a silver sedan and a semi truck whose driver stood beside the cab talking on his phone. Picnic tables sat under a covered pavilion, and a few families clustered there, eating sandwiches and corralling small children.

I killed the engine and the sudden silence felt profound after hours of road noise. Cruz stretched in the passenger seat, his joints cracking audibly.

"I need to walk," Ashley announced from the back. "My legs have forgotten how to work."

We filed out into the late afternoon air, warm and pine-scented. Ashley did an exaggerated series of stretches, touching her toes and rotating her shoulders. Cruz headed for the vending machines mounted on the bathroom building's exterior wall.

"Snacks?" he called back.

"Something with caffeine," I said.

"Chips," Ashley added.

I leaned against the Winnebago's side, enjoying the stillness. A minivan pulled in two spaces over, and a harried mother emerged with three kids who immediately sprinted for the bathroom. The truck driver finished his call and climbed back into his cab.

Cruz returned with an armful of supplies: two energy drinks, a Coke, and several bags of chips. He distributed them, and we stood there in a loose triangle, eating and watching the parking lot's mundane theater.

"You know what would really sell it?" Ashley said suddenly, looking at Cruz.

"Sell what?" Cruz asked around a mouthful of chips.

"The whole girlfriend-boyfriend thing. We're not very convincing."

I laughed. "You were literally sitting on his lap for half an hour."

"That was practical," Ashley said. "I mean the romantic stuff. The little gestures."

Cruz raised an eyebrow. "What kind of gestures?"

"Like, you should tuck my hair behind my ear or something. That's what boyfriends do in movies."

"That's what boyfriends do in bad movies," Cruz said.

"Prove it," Ashley said, grinning. "Show me your moves."

Cruz looked at me, and I shrugged, trying not to laugh. "Don't look at me. This is between you and your pretend girlfriend."

"This is insane," Cruz said, but he was smiling. He set down his energy drink on the RV's bumper and stepped closer to Ashley. "Okay, fine. I'll play along."

Ashley stood very still, watching him with barely suppressed amusement. Cruz reached up slowly, theatrically, and carefully lifted a strand of hair that had fallen across her face. He tucked it behind her ear with exaggerated gentleness, like he was handling something incredibly fragile.

"There," he said. "Very romantic. I'm basically Ryan Gosling."

Ashley snorted. "That was pretty good, actually. Very tender."

"I contain multitudes," Cruz said.

"You know what else boyfriends do?" Ashley asked.

"I'm afraid to guess," Cruz said.

"They kiss their girlfriends."

The parking lot seemed to get quieter. The truck driver's engine started with a diesel rumble, and the minivan family emerged from the bathroom and piled back into their vehicle. Cruz glanced at me again, and I could see the question in his expression.

I held up my hands. "You two are running this show. I'm just watching the performance."

"It would be really convincing," Ashley said to Cruz. "Really sell the bit."

"You're out of your mind," Cruz said, but he was laughing.

"Probably," Ashley agreed. "But think about how funny it'll be. We can tell people we're together and really commit to the story."

"What people?" Cruz asked. "We're in the middle of nowhere."

"Future people. Campground neighbors. Random hikers. We'll need to be prepared."

Cruz shook his head, still grinning. "This is the weirdest road trip I've ever been on, and we're three hours in."

"Is that a yes?" Ashley asked.

"I just want to confirm," Cruz said, looking at me. "You're cool with this?"

"I'm entertained by this," I said. "There's a difference."

"Close enough," Cruz said.

He turned back to Ashley, and she looked up at him with an expression of exaggerated expectation, batting her eyelashes like a cartoon character. Cruz started laughing, and Ashley joined him, and for a moment they just stood there giggling like teenagers.

"Okay, okay," Cruz said, composing himself. "I can do this. Professional actor right here."

"Very professional," Ashley said.

Cruz put his hands on her shoulders, formal and careful, like they were about to dance at a middle school event. Ashley bit her lip to keep from laughing. He leaned down slowly, giving her plenty of time to pull away if she wanted, and pressed his lips to hers in a kiss that lasted maybe two seconds.

When they separated, Ashley immediately burst into laughter, covering her mouth with her hand. Cruz stepped back, shaking his head.

"Well?" he asked. "Convinced?"

"That was the most awkward kiss I've ever experienced," Ashley said through her laughter.

"You asked for it," Cruz said.

"I did. I absolutely did."

I was grinning so hard my face hurt. "You two look like you're in a high school play."

"Excuse me, that was very authentic," Cruz said. "I've seen real relationships. I know how they work."

"When?" Ashley asked. "Because that felt like you learned kissing from a WikiHow article."

"I'm out of practice," Cruz said. "Give me a break."

"Do you want to try again?" Ashley asked. "Maybe it gets less weird the second time."

"Absolutely not," Cruz said, laughing. "I've fulfilled my boyfriend duties. I'm done."

"Fair enough," Ashley said. She picked up her Coke from where she'd set it on the bumper and took a long drink. "That was hilarious though."

"Glad I could entertain," Cruz said.

The semi truck pulled out of the parking lot, its air brakes hissing. A couple in their sixties climbed out of a small RV three spaces down and headed for the bathroom, moving with the stiff gait of people who'd been driving too long.

"We should probably get moving," I said, checking my phone. "Still got an hour to the campground."

"I'll drive," Ashley said. "You two have been doing all the work."

"You sure?" I asked.

"It's like driving a regular vehicle, right? Just bigger and slower and more terrifying?"

"Exactly like that," Cruz said.

We gathered up our trash and empty chip bags, depositing them in the rest stop's overflowing garbage can. Ashley climbed into the driver's seat while Cruz and I settled into the dinette booth, spreading out now that we had the space to ourselves.

The engine turned over smoothly, and Ashley adjusted the mirrors with careful attention, checking her blind spots twice before pulling out of the parking space.

"How's it feel?" I called up to her.

"Like I'm piloting a small building," she called back. "But I think I've got it."

We merged back onto the highway, the Winnebago swaying slightly as Ashley got used to the steering response. Cruz pulled out his phone and queued up a playlist, and music filled the cabin, something upbeat with guitars and a driving rhythm.

The trail cut through coastal forest for the first half mile, Douglas firs towering overhead and sword ferns crowding the edges of the packed dirt path. We'd parked the Winnebago at the trailhead lot an hour after sunrise, and the morning air still carried the cool dampness of fog that hadn't quite burned off. Ashley led the way, setting a steady pace, while Cruz and I followed with day packs containing water and snacks.

The trees thinned gradually, and suddenly we emerged onto a headland where the world opened up into nothing but ocean and sky. The Pacific stretched to the horizon in shades of gray-blue, waves rolling in with methodical patience to crash against black rocks far below. The trail followed the cliff edge, dipping and rising with the natural contours of the coastline.

"This is incredible," Ashley said, stopping at a viewpoint where someone had built a rough bench from driftwood logs.

I pulled out my camera and framed a shot of the sea stacks jutting from the water offshore, their tops crowned with wind-bent trees and bird nests. The shutter clicked, capturing the scene in sharp detail.

"Get a picture of us," Ashley said, gesturing to Cruz.

"Your public demands couple photos?" I asked.

"We need evidence of our love," Ashley said seriously. "For Instagram."

Cruz shook his head but moved to stand beside her at the cliff edge. They posed awkwardly at first, standing shoulder to shoulder like coworkers at a conference, until Ashley laughed and wrapped her arm around his waist.

"More convincing," she instructed. "We're supposed to be madly in love."

"Right, sorry," Cruz said, draping his arm over her shoulders. "How's this?"

I looked through the viewfinder. "You both look like you're being held hostage."

"We're working with what we've got," Cruz said.

I took a few shots anyway, catching them against the backdrop of ocean and sky. A couple in their forties rounded the bend in the trail, dressed in

serious hiking gear with trekking poles and hydration packs. They nodded politely as they passed.

"Beautiful day," the woman said.

"Gorgeous," Ashley agreed.

As soon as they were out of earshot, Ashley turned to Cruz with a mischievous expression I was beginning to recognize as dangerous.

"You know what would really make these photos authentic?" she asked.

"I'm afraid to guess," Cruz said.

"A real kiss. Like an actual couple would do at a scenic overlook."

Cruz glanced at me, then back at Ashley. "We already did the kiss thing."

"That was a practice kiss," Ashley said. "This is the real deal. For the photo documentation."

"You're insane," Cruz said, but he was grinning.

"Reid, you ready with the camera?" Ashley asked.

I raised it, looking through the viewfinder. "I'm capturing this trainwreck, yes."

Ashley didn't wait for further discussion. She stepped closer to Cruz, threw both arms around his neck, and pulled him down into a kiss that was significantly less awkward than the rest stop version. This time there was no hesitation, no theatrical buildup. She kissed him hard and sudden, and I saw Cruz's eyes widen in surprise for a split second before he recovered and kissed her back.

I kept shooting, the shutter firing in rapid succession. Through the lens I watched Ashley tilt her head, watched Cruz's hands come up to her waist, watched the whole absurd performance play out against the ocean backdrop. The kiss lasted maybe five seconds, long enough that I caught several frames, and then Ashley pulled back and immediately stuck her tongue out at me, her eyes bright with laughter.

Cruz looked dazed. "That was different."

"That was commitment to the bit," Ashley said. "Did you get it?" she asked me.

"Oh, I got it," I said, checking the camera's display. The photos were actually good. They looked like a real couple stealing a moment on a romantic hike, not two people engaged in an elaborate joke.

"Let me see," Ashley said, coming over to look at the screen. Cruz followed, peering over her shoulder.

"We look extremely convincing," Ashley said with satisfaction.

"We look like we actually like each other," Cruz said.

"Method acting," Ashley said. "I'm very dedicated."

An older couple appeared on the trail coming from the opposite direction, and Ashley immediately grabbed Cruz's hand, lacing their fingers together. They stood there smiling as the couple passed, looking for all the world like young lovers on a getaway.

"What a lovely spot," the older woman said.

"It really is," Ashley said, squeezing Cruz's hand.

The couple continued past, and once they were out of sight, Cruz looked down at their joined hands.

"You're really selling this," he said.

"I told you, I commit," Ashley said, but she let go and continued down the trail.

We hiked for another mile, the path winding through patches of forest and emerging repeatedly at viewpoints that offered sweeping ocean vistas. Ashley kept up a running commentary about their fake relationship, inventing elaborate backstories about how they met and fell in love.

"It was at a hardware store," she announced at one point. "Cruz was buying wood screws, and I was getting paint samples."

"Romantic," I said.

"Our eyes met over the drill bits," Cruz added. "I knew immediately she was the one."

"Because I was holding a level, and he appreciated that I care about straight lines," Ashley continued.

"It's important in a relationship," Cruz said.

At another viewpoint, Ashley insisted on more photos, and this time she initiated the kiss before I even had the camera ready. I scrambled to capture it, getting a slightly blurry shot of her on her toes, arms around Cruz's neck, him bending down to meet her. When they separated, both of them were laughing again.

"You're getting better at this," Ashley told Cruz.

"Practice makes perfect," he said.

"Should I be concerned?" I asked.

"Probably," Ashley said cheerfully.

We reached the trail's terminus at a rocky beach where massive driftwood logs lay scattered like fallen giants. The tide was out, leaving tide pools full of anemones and tiny crabs. Ashley climbed onto one of the logs and

walked its length with her arms out for balance, while Cruz and I explored the pools, pointing out sea stars and hermit crabs.

"Photo op," Ashley called from her perch on the log.

Cruz climbed up beside her, and they sat together with their legs dangling, the ocean behind them and the forested headland rising to their right. I took several shots from different angles, and in each one they looked comfortable together, natural, like they'd been a couple for years instead of pretending for less than twenty-four hours.

The hike back went faster, all of us eager to get to the RV and change out of our sweaty hiking clothes. We passed several more groups on the trail, and each time Ashley found some way to emphasize her relationship with Cruz, holding his hand, leaning against his shoulder, once even stopping to fix his collar like a doting girlfriend.

By the time we reached the parking lot, the sun had climbed high enough to burn off the remaining fog, and the day had turned warm. The Winnebago sat exactly where we'd left it, its white and tan exterior bright in the midday light.

"I need a shower," Ashley announced, unlocking the door.

"The campground has facilities," I said. "We can hook up to water there."

"How far?" she asked.

"Twenty minutes, maybe."

The town materialized along the coast like something from a postcard, its main street running parallel to the beach for six blocks of weathered storefronts and restaurants with outdoor patios. We found parking in a public lot two streets back, maneuvering the Winnebago into a space that technically fit but required Cruz to make a three-point turn while Ashley and I stood outside directing traffic.

"We're good," I called, and Cruz killed the engine.

The late afternoon sun slanted across the rooftops, casting long shadows down the side streets. Even from the parking lot I could hear music drifting from the main drag, a mix of live bands and bar speakers creating a wall of sound that spoke of weekend crowds and tourist money.

"This place is perfect," Ashley said, looking toward the center of town. "I saw reviews online. Supposed to have great nightlife."

We walked down to the main street and immediately got swallowed by the energy of it. Couples strolled hand in hand, groups of friends laughed outside brewery entrances, and families with small children navigated

around teenagers on skateboards. The restaurants were already filling up despite the early hour, their patios packed with people drinking beer and eating fish tacos.

"There must be twenty bars on this street," Cruz said, reading the signs as we passed. "The Anchor, The Driftwood, Saltwater Brewing, Neptune's..."

"We should go out tonight," Ashley said. "Like really go out. Hit the bars, maybe some of the clubs."

"Clubs?" I asked. "What clubs?"

Ashley pointed down the street where a two-story building advertised live music and dancing with a neon sign that flickered in the daylight. "That one. And I saw at least two others on the walk over."

"I didn't pack club clothes," Cruz said.

"You're fine as you are," Ashley said. "But I think we should take the whole boyfriend-girlfriend thing public tonight. Really commit to it in front of actual people."

Cruz and I exchanged a glance. "You want to pretend to be a couple at a nightclub," I said slowly.

"Why not? It'll be hilarious. We can dance, get drinks, see if anyone believes it."

"This is escalating rapidly," Cruz said.

"That's what makes it fun," Ashley said. Her eyes were bright with the kind of mischief I recognized from when she got an idea she found particularly entertaining. "Come on. When else are we going to get to do something this ridiculous?"

"Fair point," I said.

"Give me thirty minutes," Ashley said, and she turned and headed back toward the RV before either of us could respond.

Cruz and I continued exploring the main street, ducking into a surf shop to browse racks of board shorts and wetsuits we didn't need, then stopping at a coffee place for iced lattes we drank while sitting on a bench overlooking the beach. The ocean rolled in with hypnotic consistency, and the salt air mixed with coffee and fried food from nearby restaurants.

"Your girlfriend is insane," Cruz said.

"She's creative," I said. "There's a difference."

"That's one word for it."

We made our way back to the parking lot as the thirty-minute mark approached, finding the Winnebago right where we'd left it. The door was

locked, and when I knocked, Ashley called out that she needed five more minutes.

Cruz leaned against the side of the RV, checking his phone. "Should I be worried about this?"

"Probably," I said.

The door opened, and Ashley stepped out.

I actually felt my brain stutter. Cruz straightened up so fast he nearly dropped his phone.

She wore a black dress that hugged every curve, ending high on her thighs and cut low enough at the neckline to be attention-grabbing without crossing into inappropriate. The fabric had a subtle sheen that caught the light when she moved. Her legs looked impossibly long in heeled sandals I'd never seen before, black straps winding up her ankles.

But the dress was only part of it. She'd done something with her makeup that made her eyes look huge and dark, her cheekbones sharp, her lips a deep red that looked almost burgundy in the fading sunlight. Her hair, which had been in a ponytail all day, now fell in loose waves past her shoulders.

"Holy shit," Cruz said.

Ashley grinned, clearly pleased with the reaction. "I brought options."

"Options," I repeated, still trying to process the transformation. "When did you pack that?"

"Last minute decision," she said, doing a small spin that made the dress flare slightly. "I thought we might go out somewhere nice, and I didn't want to be stuck in hiking clothes."

"That's not hiking clothes," Cruz said. "That's not even the same category as hiking clothes."

"You like it?" Ashley asked, though the question was clearly rhetorical given our expressions.

"You look incredible," I managed.

"Different," Cruz added. "Very different from the person who was scrambling over rocks and looking at tide pools six hours ago."

Ashley came down the RV steps carefully, navigating the height in her heels. Up close the transformation was even more striking. She smelled like perfume I didn't recognize, something sophisticated that definitely hadn't come out of her hiking backpack.

"So here's what I'm thinking," she said, positioning herself between Cruz and me. "We go to dinner first, somewhere nice on the main street. Then we hit the bars. Cruz and I play the couple, really sell it to strangers. Dancing, drinks, the whole experience."

"And what am I doing during this performance?" I asked.

"You're the supportive friend," Ashley said. "The third wheel who's totally cool with his buddy dating his ex or his college friend or whatever story we come up with."

"This gets more elaborate by the minute," I said.

"It's called world-building," Ashley said. "Every good story needs details."

She looked at Cruz, who was still staring at her like she'd materialized from another dimension. "What do you think? Can you handle being my boyfriend for the night?"

Cruz blinked. "I think you're going to get a lot of attention in that dress."

"That's sort of the point," Ashley said.

"I mean like, a concerning amount of attention."

"I'll have my boyfriend to protect me," Ashley said, linking her arm through his. "Won't I?"

"This is surreal," Cruz said, but he didn't pull away.

Ashley looked down at herself, adjusting the dress slightly. "Too much?"

"No," I said. "It's perfect. You look perfect."

"Just unexpected," Cruz added.

"Good," Ashley said. "I like keeping you two on your toes."

We locked up the RV and headed back toward the main street, Ashley between us in her heels clicking on the pavement. People definitely noticed her. I watched heads turn as we passed, saw guys do double-takes, noticed women giving her appreciative or envious glances.

"Where should we eat?" Ashley asked, seemingly oblivious to the attention.

"Somewhere with a liquor license," Cruz said. "I'm going to need a drink for this."

We passed a seafood restaurant with a wait list, a pizza place packed with families, and finally stopped outside a steakhouse that looked upscale but not pretentious. Through the windows I could see dim lighting, white tablecloths, and a bar area with leather stools.

"This works," I said.

Ashley checked her reflection in the window, smoothing her hair. "How do I look?"

"Like trouble," Cruz said.

"Like you're about to make a lot of waiters very attentive," I added.

She smiled, that same mischievous expression from earlier. "Perfect. Let's go."

The hostess greeted us with professional warmth and led us to a table near the back, away from the bar noise but still with a view of the room. Ashley slid into the booth first, and Cruz hesitated for just a moment before sliding in beside her instead of across from her. I took the opposite side, watching them settle into their roles.

The waiter appeared almost immediately, a guy probably our age with practiced charm and an eye for Ashley that he tried and failed to keep subtle.

"Can I start you folks with drinks?" he asked, his attention locked on her.

Ashley leaned slightly against Cruz, her hand finding his on the table. "What do you think, babe? Should we get a bottle of wine?"

The restaurant hummed with conversation and the clatter of silverware on plates, voices bouncing off exposed brick walls and the tin ceiling tiles that gave the place its industrial charm. Our table sat tucked into a corner near the kitchen, offering a view of the entire dining room and the bar where groups of people waited for tables.

Cruz and I had been sitting across from each other for about ten minutes, making small talk about the menu, when Ashley returned from the bathroom and surveyed the seating arrangement with theatrical disappointment.

"This won't do," she said.

"What won't?" Cruz asked.

"We're supposed to be a couple. I can't be all the way over there." She gestured to the empty side of the booth next to Cruz.

"There's a whole seat," Cruz pointed out.

"Couples don't sit across from each other when they're out with friends," Ashley said. "That's like, dating one-on-one."

Before Cruz could respond, she maneuvered herself onto his lap, settling in like she was claiming a chair. The booth was designed for four people to sit comfortably, but Ashley had apparently decided comfort was less important than commitment to the performance.

Cruz's hands hovered uncertainly for a moment before landing on her waist, helping her balance. "This is how we're doing dinner?"

"This is how couples do dinner," Ashley said, reaching for her wine glass. "Right, Reid?"

I picked up my own glass, watching them with undisguised amusement. "I'm staying out of this."

The waiter returned to take our order, and if he found anything unusual about Ashley's seating choice, his professional training kept him from showing it. He recommended the ribeye, mentioned that the salmon was particularly good tonight, and refilled our water glasses with practiced efficiency.

Ashley ordered the scallops, Cruz got the steak, and I went with the salmon. As soon as the waiter left, Ashley shifted her weight, getting more comfortable on Cruz's lap.

"You good?" she asked him.

"My legs are going to fall asleep," Cruz said.

"Suffer for love," Ashley said, patting his cheek.

Our appetizers arrived, and Ashley immediately speared a piece of calamari from the shared plate and held it up to Cruz's mouth.

"Really?" Cruz asked.

"Open up," Ashley said.

I took a long drink of wine to keep from laughing. Cruz opened his mouth, and Ashley fed him the calamari, watching his face with exaggerated attentiveness.

"Good?" she asked.

"It's fried squid," Cruz said after swallowing. "It's objectively good."

"You're supposed to say it's delicious because I fed it to you," Ashley said.

"It's delicious because you fed it to me," Cruz repeated dutifully.

She rewarded him by feeding him another piece, and I pulled out my phone to capture a photo of the absurdity. Through the screen I watched Ashley lean against Cruz's chest, one arm around his shoulders, while she navigated the appetizer plate with her free hand.

"You two are going to give our waiter ideas," I said.

"Good," Ashley said. "We're creating a narrative. Young couple madly in love, celebrating a road trip with their friend who's definitely not bitter about being single."

"I'm not single," I pointed out.

"You are tonight," Ashley said. "I'm with Cruz now. We talked about this."

Our entrees came, and Ashley finally relocated to her own seat so they could both eat properly, though she made a point of stealing bites from Cruz's plate and offering him pieces of her scallops. The restaurant filled up around us, the noise level rising as more tables filled and the bar crowd grew louder.

We finished dinner around nine, paid the check, and walked back out into the night. The main street had transformed completely. The families had disappeared, replaced by groups in their twenties and thirties moving between bars, their voices carrying over the music that poured from open doorways.

The nightclub Ashley had spotted earlier occupied a converted warehouse two blocks from the beach, its entrance marked by red rope barriers and a bored-looking bouncer checking IDs. The bass line from inside vibrated through the sidewalk.

"This is the place," Ashley said, her eyes bright with anticipation.

We paid the cover and pushed through the doors into a wall of sound and bodies. The club was packed, the dance floor a mass of movement under colored lights that swept and pulsed with the music. The bar ran the length of one wall, three deep with people shouting orders at harried bartenders.

Cruz leaned close to my ear to be heard over the noise. "This is going to be interesting."

Ashley grabbed both our hands and pulled us toward the bar, navigating through the crowd with determined efficiency. She ordered three shots of tequila, and we threw them back standing pressed together by necessity in the crush of people.

"Dance floor," Ashley announced, and before Cruz could protest she was pulling him into the crowd.

I followed at a distance, finding a spot at the edge of the dance floor where I could watch. The music was loud enough to feel in my chest, some remix of a pop song I half-recognized, and the lights made everyone look slightly unreal.

Ashley pressed herself against Cruz, her arms around his neck, moving with the music. Cruz's hands found her waist, and they moved together in the strobing light, their bodies close in a way that looked entirely

convincing. Ashley said something in his ear, and he laughed, and then she pulled his head down and kissed him.

Not the playful pecks from the hiking trail. This was a real kiss, her mouth open against his, their bodies pressed together from chest to hips. It lasted long enough that people around them noticed, long enough that I pulled out my phone and took a few photos because the absurdity of it demanded documentation.

When they separated, Ashley looked over Cruz's shoulder and caught my eye, grinning and giving me a thumbs up like she'd just accomplished something remarkable.

They danced through three songs, Ashley grinding against Cruz in ways that made several nearby guys watch with obvious envy. Cruz, to his credit, seemed to have fully committed to the role, his hands on her hips, matching her movements, occasionally leaning down to say something in her ear that made her laugh.

I went to the bar and got another drink, nursing it while watching the show. A woman around my age materialized beside me, shouting something I couldn't quite hear over the music.

"What?" I shouted back.

"Are those your friends?" she asked, pointing at Cruz and Ashley.

"Yeah."

"They're really into each other," she said.

"They really are," I agreed.

Ashley chose that moment to kiss Cruz again, her fingers tangled in his hair, and the woman beside me whistled appreciatively.

"Relationship goals," she said, then disappeared back into the crowd.

The music shifted to something slower, and Ashley finally extracted herself from Cruz and made her way over to where I stood. Her makeup had held up remarkably well despite the heat and exertion, though her hair was slightly disheveled.

"Having fun?" I asked.

"This is amazing," she shouted. "Did you see everyone watching us?"

"Pretty sure the whole club saw you."

"Cruz is a good sport," she said, glancing back at where he stood waiting on the dance floor. "He's really committing."

"You're both committing pretty hard."

"It's fun though, right? Playing pretend in public?"

"It's definitely something," I said.

Ashley grabbed my arm. "Come dance with us. You look lonely over here."

She pulled me back onto the floor, and the three of us formed a loose triangle, shouting over the music about nothing important. But within two songs, Ashley had gravitated back to Cruz, her arms around him again, and I drifted back to my observation post at the edge of the crowd.

They danced for another hour, breaking only for bathroom runs and another round of drinks. Each time Ashley returned to the floor, she found Cruz and pressed against him like a heat-seeking missile, and each time Cruz responded like this was the most natural thing in the world.

Around midnight, Ashley finally signaled that she was ready to leave. We pushed through the crowd toward the exit, emerging into cool night air that felt shocking after the heat of the club.

"That was perfect," Ashley said, her voice hoarse from shouting over music. She walked between us, her heels clicking on the sidewalk, one hand holding Cruz's arm for balance.

"My ears are ringing," Cruz said.

"Small price for love," Ashley said.

The main street had quieted somewhat, though several bars still had crowds spilling onto their patios. We navigated back toward the parking lot, Ashley walking with careful attention to her footing now that the adrenaline was wearing off.

The RV park sat on a bluff overlooking the ocean, thirty or forty sites arranged in neat rows with electrical hookups and picnic tables. We'd claimed a spot near the edge with a partial view of the water, and after hooking up to power and water, we'd changed into swimsuits and made our way down the wooden staircase that descended the cliff face to the beach below.

The sand stretched in both directions, dotted with families under umbrellas and groups of college-aged kids playing volleyball. The surf was moderate, waves rolling in with enough force to be fun but not dangerous. Gulls wheeled overhead, their cries mixing with the sound of breaking waves and distant laughter.

Ashley emerged from behind a beach towel she'd been using to change, and I realized the bikini situation was going to be a problem for Cruz. It was red, minimal, and left very little to the imagination. The top consisted

of two small triangles connected by strings, and the bottoms rode high on her hips in a way that made her legs look even longer than the dress had last night.

Cruz, to his credit, managed to keep his expression mostly neutral when he saw her, though I caught the slight widening of his eyes.

"Water looks cold," he said, which was a safe thing to say.

"Only one way to find out," Ashley said, and took off running toward the surf.

Cruz and I followed at a more reasonable pace, hitting the waterline just as a wave retreated and left cold foam swirling around our ankles.

"Jesus," Cruz said.

"Pacific Ocean," I said. "It's never warm."

Ashley was already waist-deep, diving under an incoming wave and emerging with her hair slicked back, whooping at the cold. Cruz and I waded in more cautiously, taking our time to adjust to the temperature.

We swam for maybe twenty minutes, body-surfing the smaller waves and diving under the larger ones, until the cold finally drove us back to shore. Our towels lay where we'd left them, weighted down with shoes and a beach bag. Ashley collapsed onto hers with a satisfied sigh, stretching out in the sun like a cat.

"That was amazing," she said.

"That was hypothermia," Cruz said, rubbing his arms.

I sat down on my towel and pulled out the sunscreen, offering it around. Ashley took it and squeezed some into her palm, then looked at Cruz.

"Can you get my back?" she asked.

"Sure," Cruz said, and she turned to give him access.

He applied the sunscreen with careful, impersonal efficiency, like he was performing a medical procedure, and I had to admire his self-control. Ashley clearly had no such compunctions. When he finished, she turned back around and positioned herself facing him, sitting cross-legged.

"That feels better," she said. "I burn so easily."

A family walked past, parents corralling two small children who were covered head to toe in sand. A teenage couple sat about twenty yards away, wrapped up in each other and oblivious to everything else. The beach had that lazy afternoon energy, people content to just exist in the sun and salt air.

"We should get lunch after this," I said. "There was a taco place back in town."

"I could eat," Cruz said.

"Food sounds good," Ashley agreed, but she was looking at Cruz with that expression I'd learned meant she was planning something.

She shifted position, moving from cross-legged to kneeling, and then before Cruz could react, she swung one leg over his lap and settled onto him, straddling his thighs. He was sitting with his legs extended, leaning back on his hands, and suddenly Ashley was in his lap facing him, her hands on his shoulders.

"Ashley," Cruz said, his voice carrying a warning note.

"What?" she asked innocently. "I'm just getting comfortable."

"We're in public," he said.

"So? We're a couple, remember? Couples sit like this at the beach all the time."

She leaned in and kissed him, her hands sliding from his shoulders to the back of his neck. It wasn't a quick peck. Her mouth moved against his with studied intent, her body pressed close, and I watched Cruz's hands come up to her waist automatically, like muscle memory from the nightclub.

The kiss lasted long enough that an older couple walking past gave them a disapproving look. Long enough that I could see Cruz's fingers tighten on Ashley's hips. When they finally broke apart, Ashley was grinning.

"You're going to get us kicked off this beach," Cruz said, but his voice was rougher than it had been.

"Relax," Ashley said. She reached behind her for the beach towel and pulled it over Cruz's lap, draping it across both of them like a blanket. "There. More modest."

"That's not really helping," Cruz said.

Ashley shifted her weight, settling more firmly onto his lap, and her hand disappeared under the towel. I watched her arm move, watched her hand slide down between them, and then Cruz's entire body went rigid.

Ashley's eyes locked onto mine, her grin widening into something wicked. She was looking directly at me while her hand moved under that towel, watching my reaction, and then she laughed, bright and clear in the ocean air.

"Ashley," Cruz said again, his voice strained.

"What?" she asked, still looking at me. "I'm just adjusting the towel."

Her hand was absolutely not adjusting the towel. I could see the movement of her arm, could see exactly where her hand had gone, could see Cruz's jaw clench as he tried to maintain some semblance of composure.

"You're insane," I said.

"I'm thorough," Ashley corrected. "If we're going to pretend to be a couple, we should be convincing."

"There are children on this beach," Cruz managed.

"The towel is very strategically placed," Ashley said. "No one can see anything."

But I could see her arm moving, could see the way Cruz's breathing had changed, could see the flush creeping up his neck. Ashley maintained eye contact with me the entire time, her expression pure mischief, like she was daring me to object.

"How's the water temperature now?" she asked Cruz sweetly.

"Not cold enough," he said through gritted teeth.

She laughed again and finally, mercifully, removed her hand from under the towel. But she stayed on his lap, settling back with her arms around his neck like this was the most natural position in the world.

"We really should get lunch," I said, looking away toward the ocean.

"In a minute," Ashley said. "I'm comfortable."

A volleyball bounced past our towels, and one of the college guys jogged over to retrieve it, giving Ashley an appreciative look before returning to his game.

"You're collecting admirers," Cruz said.

"They're looking at us," Ashley corrected. "The cute couple on the beach."

"The couple that's going to get arrested for public indecency," Cruz said.

"So dramatic," Ashley said, but she finally climbed off his lap and stretched out on her own towel, lying on her stomach with her head pillowed on her arms.

Cruz stayed sitting exactly where he was, the towel still strategically draped, and I caught his eye. He shook his head slightly, a gesture that conveyed both exasperation and something else I couldn't quite identify.

We stayed at the beach another thirty minutes, letting the sun dry the salt water from our skin and warm us through. Ashley dozed, or pretended to doze, while Cruz and I talked about nothing important, the quality of the

surf, the RV's fuel consumption, whether we should camp at the next spot for two nights instead of one.

Eventually Ashley sat up, squinting in the bright light. "Okay, now I'm actually hungry."

We gathered our things, shaking sand from towels and stuffing them into the beach bag. Ashley pulled a cover-up over her bikini, a thin white fabric that was somehow more suggestive than the bikini itself, and we made our way back up the wooden staircase to the bluff.

The RV sat exactly where we'd left it, its white exterior bright in the afternoon sun. A couple in the next site over waved as we passed, and Ashley waved back, friendly and casual, like she hadn't just been doing something wildly inappropriate on a public beach twenty minutes ago.

Inside the RV, the air was stale and hot from being closed up. Cruz opened windows while I turned on the roof vent fan, and Ashley disappeared into the bathroom to change out of her bikini.

"That taco place is maybe fifteen minutes back toward town," I said, pulling up directions on my phone.

"Sounds good," Cruz said. He was looking out the window at the ocean, his expression unreadable.

Ashley emerged in shorts and a tank top, her hair still damp and wavy from the salt water. "Ready?"

We piled back into the truck, leaving the RV to cool down in our absence, and headed back down the coastal highway toward town.

The bedroom occupied the entire rear section of the RV, maybe eight feet by ten, with storage compartments built into the walls and a queen-sized bed that took up most of the floor space. We'd spent the evening at a campfire outside, roasting hot dogs and making s'mores with a family from two sites over, and when we finally retreated inside around ten o'clock, the RV's interior felt warm and close after the cool night air.

I was up front making coffee for the morning, setting up the pot so we could just turn it on when we woke up, when I heard Ashley's laugh from the back bedroom followed by a thump.

"What are you doing back there?" I called.

"Teaching Cruz a lesson," Ashley's voice came back, slightly breathless.

I walked toward the bedroom, curious, and found them on the bed in what could only be described as a wrestling match. Ashley had Cruz pinned somehow, her weight on his chest, his arms trapped under her knees. The

bed took up so much space that there was barely room to stand in the doorway, and I leaned against the frame to watch.

"A lesson in what?" I asked.

"Respect," Ashley said. "He said I couldn't take him in a fight."

"I said you probably couldn't," Cruz corrected, his voice muffled by the fact that Ashley was sitting on him. "There's a difference."

"Semantics," Ashley said.

She shifted her weight, and Cruz took the opportunity to free one arm and grab her waist. In one motion he rolled them both sideways, using momentum and the bed's limited space to reverse their positions. Suddenly Ashley was on her back and Cruz was above her, his hands pinning her wrists to the mattress.

"See?" he said. "Basic physics."

"Cheater," Ashley said, but she was grinning.

The overhead light in the bedroom cast shadows across them, highlighting the angles of Cruz's shoulders and the curve of Ashley's throat. They were both breathing harder than the brief exertion warranted, and I watched Ashley test his grip on her wrists, trying to pull free.

"Reid, are you just going to stand there and let him win?" she asked.

"This is between you two," I said.

Ashley managed to get one leg between them and pushed, creating enough space to twist partially sideways. Cruz adjusted his grip, catching her around the waist, and they rolled again, this time ending up with both of them on their sides facing each other.

"You're stronger than you look," Ashley said.

"You're more trouble than you look," Cruz countered.

Ashley laughed and suddenly lunged forward, her mouth finding the side of his neck. Cruz jerked in surprise, and I saw Ashley's teeth press into his skin, not hard enough to truly hurt but enough to make him react.

"Did you just bite me?" Cruz asked, incredulous.

"Fighting dirty," Ashley said against his neck. "No rules in wrestling."

Cruz's hand came up to the back of her head, tangled in her hair, and he pulled her back just enough to look at her face. "That's how we're playing this?"

"That's how I'm playing it," Ashley said.

They stared at each other for a moment, both breathing hard, their faces inches apart in the cramped space of the bed. The RV's air conditioning

hummed, cycling cool air through the bedroom, but the temperature seemed to have risen anyway.

Cruz moved first, using his grip in her hair to tilt her head back, exposing her throat. For a second I thought he might actually bite her back, match her energy, but instead he just held her there, watching her face.

"Yield?" he asked.

"Never," Ashley said.

He released her hair and grabbed her waist instead, rolling them one more time until he had her pinned beneath him again, his weight distributed carefully so he wasn't crushing her but she couldn't easily escape. Her wrists were above her head, caught in one of his hands, and her legs were trapped under his.

"Now yield," Cruz said.

Ashley tested his hold, arching her back and trying to twist free, but Cruz had the advantage of leverage and size. She was strong for her frame, but physics wasn't on her side.

"Reid, help," she said, laughing.

"You got yourself into this," I said from the doorway.

"Some boyfriend you are," she said to Cruz. "Pinning your girlfriend to the bed."

"You started it," Cruz pointed out.

"I did," Ashley agreed. "But I'm not yielding."

They stayed like that for another few seconds, Ashley pinned and Cruz holding her in place, and I could see the moment when the playfulness started to shift into something else. Cruz's breathing had changed, gotten deeper, and Ashley had stopped struggling, her body gone still beneath him.

"We should probably stop," Cruz said quietly.

"Probably," Ashley agreed, but neither of them moved immediately.

Finally Cruz released her wrists and rolled off her, sitting up on the edge of the bed. Ashley stayed where she was for a moment, catching her breath, then sat up as well, running her hands through her hair to smooth it.

"I still think I could take you," she said, but her voice had lost some of its playful edge.

"Sure," Cruz said. "Keep telling yourself that."

I stepped back from the doorway to give them space to exit the bedroom. Cruz came out first, his shirt slightly twisted from the wrestling, and headed

for the bathroom. Ashley followed a moment later, her face flushed and her hair wild.

"That was fun," she said to me as she passed.

"Looked intense," I said.

"Just playing around," Ashley said, but she wouldn't quite meet my eyes.

Cruz emerged from the bathroom and grabbed a water bottle from the fridge, draining half of it in one go. Ashley flopped onto the dinette booth, pulling out her phone and scrolling through it with exaggerated focus.

The energy in the RV had shifted, become charged with something that hadn't been there before. The easy playfulness from earlier in the trip felt like it had evolved into something more complicated, though no one was acknowledging it directly.

"I'm going to take a shower," Ashley announced, standing up and heading for the bathroom.

The water started running, and Cruz and I sat in the main cabin in silence for a minute.

"She's competitive," Cruz finally said.

"She really is," I agreed.

"And insane."

"Also true."

Cruz laughed, but it sounded forced. He finished his water and tossed the bottle in the recycling bin we'd set up under the sink.

"I'm going to check the propane levels," he said, which was clearly an excuse to go outside.

I heard the door open and close, leaving me alone in the RV with the sound of the shower and my own thoughts. Through the window I could see Cruz walking around the exterior, checking connections that definitely didn't need checking, keeping himself busy with invented tasks.

Ashley's shower lasted longer than usual, and when she finally emerged in pajama shorts and a tank top, her hair wrapped in a towel, Cruz still hadn't come back inside.

"Where'd he go?" she asked.

"Outside. Checking things."

"What things?"

"Everything, apparently."

Ashley sat on the couch and started combing through her wet hair. "We probably took the wrestling thing too far."

"Probably," I said.

"It was funny though."

"Parts of it were funny."

She looked at me, her expression hard to read. "You're not mad?"

"Why would I be mad?"

"I don't know. The whole thing is kind of weird when you think about it."

"Then maybe don't think about it too hard," I said.

Ashley nodded and went back to combing her hair. Cruz came back inside a few minutes later, announced he was going to shower as well, and disappeared into the bathroom. The water started up again, and Ashley and I sat in companionable silence, not quite looking at each other.

The bedroom felt even smaller with three people standing in it, the walls close enough that I could touch both sides if I spread my arms. Cruz stood near the foot of the bed, I occupied the doorway, and Ashley had squeezed into the narrow gap between the bed and the storage cabinets.

"So we need to figure out sleeping arrangements," I said, stating the obvious.

"The bed is definitely more comfortable than the dinette conversion," Cruz said. "We established that the first night."

"Those bench cushions are brutal," Ashley agreed. "My hip still hurts from night two."

We'd been rotating who slept where for the past few nights, taking turns with the comfortable memory foam mattress in back versus the significantly less comfortable pull-out situation up front. The dinette benches converted into a sleeping surface that was technically bed-sized but felt more like sleeping on a park bench with thin padding.

"We could just keep rotating," I suggested.

"Or we could settle it definitively," Ashley said. "One night, clear winner takes the bed, loser takes the benches."

"How do we settle it definitively?" Cruz asked.

"Rock-paper-scissors," Ashley said immediately. "Best two out of three."

Cruz laughed. "We're adults making major decisions through rock-paper-scissors?"

"You have a better system?" Ashley asked.

"I don't, actually."

"Then rock-paper-scissors it is," Ashley said. She looked at me. "You good with that?"

"Fine by me," I said. "Who plays who first?"

"We could do a tournament," Cruz suggested. "You and Ashley first, winner plays me."

"Or we could do couples versus singles," Ashley said, her eyes glinting with mischief. "Cruz and me against Reid."

"That's not how rock-paper-scissors works," I said.

"Sure it is. We'll throw together, and if either of us beats you, we win the round."

"That's statistically unfair," Cruz pointed out.

"Life's unfair," Ashley said. "Besides, we're a couple. Couples share beds. It makes sense."

Cruz and I exchanged a glance. The logic was twisted but not entirely wrong, and there was something appealing about just getting the decision made rather than prolonging it.

"Fine," I said. "Two out of three, you throw together, if either of you beats me, you win the round."

"Perfect," Ashley said, rubbing her hands together like a cartoon villain.

We positioned ourselves as best we could in the cramped space. Ashley and Cruz stood side by side at the foot of the bed, and I stayed in the doorway, giving us all enough room to make the hand gestures without hitting each other.

"On three," Ashley said. "One, two, three."

I threw rock. Cruz threw paper. Ashley threw scissors.

"Paper beats rock," Cruz said. "We win round one."

"Best two out of three," I reminded them.

"Right. Again. One, two, three."

I threw scissors this time. They both threw rock.

"Rock beats scissors," Ashley said, grinning. "We win."

"That was fast," I said.

"We're a good team," Ashley said, high-fiving Cruz.

Cruz shook his head but he was smiling. "I feel like we just hustled you."

"You definitely hustled me," I agreed. "But a deal's a deal."

"You can have the bed tomorrow night," Ashley offered.

"Generous of you," I said.

The reality of the situation was settling in now that the game was over. Cruz and Ashley would be sharing the bed tonight. The same bed where

they'd been wrestling an hour ago. The bed that took up this entire small room, intimate by design, meant for couples traveling together.

"I should probably get the dinette set up," I said.

"I'll help," Cruz offered, but Ashley put a hand on his arm.

"Actually, I need to change first," she said. "Into something more comfortable for sleeping."

She squeezed past me out of the bedroom and grabbed something from her bag, then disappeared into the bathroom. The door clicked shut, and Cruz and I stood in the bedroom looking at anything except each other.

"This is fine," Cruz said finally.

"Totally fine," I agreed.

"I mean, it's just sleeping. People share beds all the time."

"Right. Platonically."

"Exactly. Platonic bed-sharing."

We both knew how that sounded, but neither of us acknowledged it.

"I should convert the dinette," I said again.

This time I actually did it, moving to the front of the RV and removing the table from its mount. The cushions rearranged into a flat surface that was maybe six feet long and three feet wide, adequate for sleeping but not comfortable. I pulled out the bedding from the storage compartment and made up the makeshift bed, smoothing out the sheets and arranging the pillow.

Cruz came out of the bedroom and helped me finish, his movements efficient and practical. We worked in silence, the kind that felt heavy with things neither of us wanted to say.

The bathroom door opened, and Ashley emerged in sleep shorts and an oversized t-shirt, her hair loose around her shoulders. She'd washed her face, removing the last traces of makeup, and looked younger somehow, softer.

"All set?" she asked, looking at my converted bed.

"All set," I said.

She walked past me toward the bedroom, and Cruz followed after a moment's hesitation. I heard them moving around back there, the sounds of people getting settled, the creak of the mattress as weight shifted on it.

"Night, Reid," Ashley called out.

"Night," I called back.

"Sleep well," Cruz added, which felt like something he felt obligated to say.

I turned off the main lights, leaving just the small LED strip over the kitchen counter on for ambient light. The RV settled into nighttime quiet, just the hum of the refrigerator and the distant sound of waves from the beach below the bluff.

I lay down on the dinette conversion and immediately felt the hardness of the plywood base through the inadequate cushioning. My shoulder hit the edge where two cushions met, creating an uncomfortable ridge right at the middle of my back.

From the bedroom, I heard quiet conversation, too low to make out the words. Ashley laughed softly at something Cruz said. The mattress creaked again as they adjusted positions, finding comfortable spots in the space they were sharing.

I stared at the RV's ceiling, at the emergency escape hatch above the dinette, and tried not to think too hard about the sleeping arrangement we'd just gambled away with a children's game. The cushions were definitely as uncomfortable as I remembered. This was going to be a long night.

I was adjusting the dinette cushions for the third time, trying to find an arrangement that didn't leave a gap right where my spine would rest, when I heard the bathroom door open. I glanced up and felt my hands go still.

Ashley stood in the narrow hallway wearing what could only be described as lingerie masquerading as pajamas. The cami was deep emerald satin that caught the light with every breath, thin straps over her shoulders and a neckline that dipped low enough to show the curve of her breasts. The matching shorts were cut high on her thighs, the satin clinging to her hips and stopping just below the curve of her ass.

She walked toward the bedroom like this was completely normal, her bare feet silent on the RV's vinyl flooring. The fabric moved with her, shifting and gleaming, and I noticed Cruz had frozen in the doorway of the bedroom, a pillow in his hands.

"What?" Ashley asked, catching our stares.

"Those are your pajamas?" I asked.

"These are my comfortable sleeping clothes," she said, running a hand down the satin fabric. "Why?"

"They're a little," I paused, searching for a diplomatic word, "fancy for camping."

"I like nice things," Ashley said with a shrug. "Besides, the fabric breathes really well. Stays cool in the heat."

She moved past Cruz into the bedroom, and I watched him watch her go, his expression carefully neutral in a way that took visible effort.

"You coming?" Ashley asked Cruz from inside the room.

Cruz set the pillow on the bed and glanced back at me. I made a gesture that was supposed to communicate something like "this is fine" but probably looked more like helpless confusion.

"Yeah," Cruz said, and followed her into the bedroom.

I heard the rustle of sheets, the creak of the mattress as they both got settled. Ashley said something too quiet for me to hear, and Cruz responded in the same low tone. The overhead light in the bedroom clicked off, leaving just the ambient glow from the kitchen LED strip.

"Goodnight," I called toward the back.

"Night," Ashley's voice came back, muffled by distance and possibly by blankets.

"Sleep well," Cruz added.

I stood there for a moment, looking at my makeshift bed, then at the darkness of the bedroom doorway where I could just make out the shape of the bed and two people in it. The reality of the situation felt suddenly concrete in a way it hadn't when we were joking about rock-paper-scissors.

My girlfriend was in bed with my best friend, wearing satin that probably felt incredible against skin, under covers they were sharing in a space barely big enough for two people to exist without touching.

I turned back to the dinette and finished arranging the bedding, tucking the sheet around the cushions and placing my pillow at the end farthest from the bedroom. The whole setup looked as uninviting as it felt, but at least it was horizontal.

From the back bedroom came more quiet conversation, the kind of late-night talk that happens when people are settling in to sleep. I heard Ashley laugh softly, heard the sheets rustle again, heard what might have been her telling Cruz to stop hogging the blanket.

I stripped down to my boxers and t-shirt and lay down on the converted dinette, immediately feeling every seam and gap in the cushions. The ridge I'd noticed earlier dug into my lower back exactly as expected. I shifted positions, trying to find a comfortable spot that didn't exist.

The RV creaked as someone shifted weight in the back bedroom. I heard the distinct sound of the mattress springs, then more rustling of fabric against fabric, against skin.

"You comfortable?" Ashley's voice drifted out, slightly louder now.

"Yeah," Cruz responded. "You?"

"Very," Ashley said, and there was something in her tone I couldn't quite identify. "This mattress is so much better than those benches."

"Reid's going to be miserable," Cruz said.

"He lost fair and square," Ashley said.

More rustling, more adjustments. I stared at the ceiling of the RV, at the small emergency lights that glowed dimly in the darkness. Outside, I could hear the ocean, waves rolling in with rhythmic consistency, and somewhere far off, someone's radio playing music too faint to identify.

The RV settled into its nighttime sounds. The refrigerator compressor cycled on with a low hum. The walls creaked as the temperature dropped and materials contracted. And from the bedroom, the occasional shift of weight, the whisper of satin against cotton sheets, the soft breathing of two people finding sleep.

I turned onto my side, which made the cushion gap worse but at least took pressure off my spine. My shoulder immediately started to ache from the hardness of the plywood base, but lying on my back wasn't working either.

"You okay out there?" Ashley called.

"Fine," I said.

"Liar," she said, but affectionately. "Tomorrow night you get the bed."

"I'm holding you to that."

Silence fell again, deeper this time. I could hear Cruz's breathing evening out into the rhythm of sleep. Ashley took longer, shifting positions several times, and I tracked each movement by sound alone, building a mental picture of her in that satin cami, under those covers, inches from Cruz in a space designed for intimacy.

The cushions under me felt harder with each passing minute. I tried my other side, then my back again, then gave up and accepted that comfort wasn't happening tonight. The darkness pressed in, and the sound of the ocean became a kind of white noise that should have been soothing but wasn't.

From the bedroom, someone shifted again, and I heard the distinct sound of fabric sliding against fabric. The mattress creaked. Then silence, and breathing, and the night stretching out ahead.

I'd been looking forward to movie night since yesterday, mostly because it meant we'd all be together doing something normal after the weirdness of the sleeping arrangements. We'd stopped at a grocery store in the afternoon and picked up microwave popcorn and candy, and Cruz had queued up an action movie on his laptop that none of us had seen.

The bedroom felt cramped with three people in it, but we'd managed this before. Usually Ashley and I sat up against the headboard with pillows behind our backs, and Cruz either joined us or sat at the foot of the bed facing the screen. It worked well enough in the small space.

Tonight, Cruz had already positioned the laptop on the storage cabinet at the foot of the bed, angling it so the screen would be visible from the headboard. I climbed onto the bed and settled against the wall, arranging pillows behind me. Ashley came in carrying a bowl of popcorn, still wearing those satin sleep shorts from last night and a different cami, this one black.

"You guys ready?" Cruz asked, hovering near the doorway.

"Almost," Ashley said. She set the popcorn on the nightstand and looked at the bed setup, then at the blankets folded at the foot. "Actually, I'm kind of cold. Can we get under the covers?"

"We usually sit up for movies," I said.

"I know, but it's chilly tonight, and being under the blankets sounds nice." She looked at Cruz. "You okay with that?"

Cruz glanced at me, then back at Ashley. "Sure, I guess."

Ashley pulled back the covers and slid underneath, lying on her side with her head propped on a pillow. She patted the space next to her. "Come on."

Cruz climbed in beside her, and they arranged themselves into a configuration that looked disturbingly natural, her back against his chest, his arm around her waist, both of them on their sides facing the laptop screen. The blankets covered them from shoulders to feet, creating a cocoon that excluded me completely.

I stayed where I was, sitting up against the headboard with my legs stretched out on top of the covers, suddenly feeling like an intruder in a space where I clearly didn't fit.

"Hit play," Ashley said, settling more firmly against Cruz.

I leaned forward and clicked the trackpad, and the movie started, opening with a car chase through city streets. The speakers were small but adequate, filling the bedroom with engine noise and dramatic music.

Ashley reached out from under the covers and grabbed a handful of popcorn from the bowl on the nightstand, bringing it back under the blankets. I watched the movement, saw the way the covers shifted and settled, outlining the shapes of two bodies pressed together.

"This looks good," Cruz said, his voice coming from behind Ashley somewhere.

"I heard the reviews were solid," I said, trying to focus on the screen.

The movie progressed through its first act, establishing characters and conflict. On screen, the protagonist discovered a conspiracy. In the bed below me, Ashley shifted position, and I felt the mattress move. Her hand emerged again for more popcorn, then disappeared.

"He's definitely going to betray them," Ashley said, referring to one of the characters.

"Too obvious," Cruz said. "It's going to be the woman."

"Want to bet?" Ashley asked.

"What are the stakes?"

"Winner gets to pick breakfast tomorrow."

"Deal," Cruz said.

I contributed nothing to this exchange, watching the screen but increasingly aware of the activity happening in the lower half of my peripheral vision. The blankets moved in small, continuous adjustments. I heard fabric sliding against fabric, heard Ashley's breathing change slightly.

Twenty minutes into the movie, during a tense interrogation scene, I heard something that definitely wasn't dialogue from the laptop. A soft sound, quiet but unmistakable, that made my shoulders tense.

I kept my eyes on the screen, watching the protagonist refuse to give up information, while behind me the blankets rustled with movement that had nothing to do with getting comfortable.

Another sound, this one clearly Ashley, a small intake of breath that the movie's soundtrack didn't quite cover. The mattress shifted again, more obviously this time.

I forced myself to focus on the movie. The protagonist escaped from the interrogation room. There was another chase scene, this one on foot through crowded streets. The music swelled with tension.

Behind me, under those blankets, I heard the distinct sound of kissing. Not the quick pecks from earlier in the trip, but the deeper kind, the kind that involved tongues and breath and bodies pressed close. The mattress moved rhythmically now, subtle but constant.

"You guys watching this?" I asked, not turning around.

A pause, then Ashley's voice, slightly breathless. "Yeah, watching."

"What just happened in the scene?"

Another pause, longer this time.

"He jumped from a building," Cruz offered, which was actually correct but could have been a guess.

I heard more movement, more rustling. The kissing sounds had stopped, but the shifting of fabric continued, and I couldn't tell what was happening without turning around, and I absolutely was not going to turn around.

The movie reached its midpoint, a major revelation about the conspiracy. On screen, the protagonist looked shocked. In the bed, the blankets moved in a way that suggested someone had changed position significantly.

"I'm going to grab some water," I said, climbing off the bed without waiting for a response.

I went to the kitchen area and got a bottle from the fridge, drinking it slowly while staring out the window at the darkness of the RV park. A few lights glowed in distant campers. The sky was clear enough to see stars.

When I came back to the bedroom doorway, Ashley and Cruz were definitely not watching the movie anymore. They were still under the blankets, still in roughly the same position, but Ashley's head was tilted back and Cruz's face was against her neck. Her hand was visible above the covers, fingers tangled in his hair.

I cleared my throat. They separated slightly but didn't look particularly embarrassed.

"Movie's still going," I said.

"Right," Ashley said. "Sorry, we were just..."

"I know what you were doing," I said.

"It's not..." Cruz started.

"It's fine," I interrupted, though my voice suggested otherwise. "I'm actually pretty tired. I'm going to set up the benches."

"You sure?" Ashley asked, but she made no move to get out from under the blankets, from Cruz's arms.

"Yeah, I'm sure."

I left them there and went to convert the dinette, removing the table and arranging the cushions with practiced efficiency. I could hear the movie still playing in the bedroom, the soundtrack of explosions and gunfire, but I couldn't hear whether they'd gone back to watching it or resumed what they'd been doing before I interrupted.

I made up the bed with the sheets and blanket, changed into my sleeping clothes, and lay down on the uncomfortable cushions without brushing my teeth or doing any of my normal nighttime routine. I just wanted to be horizontal, to not be in that bedroom anymore, to not be listening to sounds I couldn't unhear.

The movie ended eventually. I heard the laptop close, heard low conversation I couldn't make out, heard the bedroom light click off. The RV settled into darkness and the kind of quiet that isn't really quiet at all when you're paying attention.

I lay on my back, staring at nothing, feeling every ridge and gap in the cushions beneath me, and tried not to think about the fact that this arrangement had somehow become normal over the course of a week. My girlfriend in bed with my best friend, under covers that hid everything and nothing, in a space so small that intimacy was inevitable.

The ocean provided its constant soundtrack beyond the RV's thin walls. Someone in a neighboring site laughed, the sound carrying through the night air. And in the back bedroom, silence, or something close to it, broken occasionally by the creak of springs and the whisper of movement I told myself I was imagining.

The card game had been Cruz's idea, something about wanting a normal evening activity that didn't involve hiking or driving or spending money in tourist towns. He'd found a deck in one of the RV's storage compartments, slightly worn but complete, and we'd set up at the dinette table with beers and pretzels and a playlist running from Ashley's phone.

We were playing gin rummy, a game simple enough that conversation could flow alongside it. The table was barely large enough for three people to have cards and personal space, our elbows occasionally colliding when someone reached for the discard pile.

"Gin," Cruz said, laying down his hand for the third time in a row.

"You're either cheating or unnaturally lucky," Ashley said, tossing her cards onto the table in mock frustration.

"I'm just good at this game," Cruz said, collecting the cards to shuffle for the next round.

Ashley stood up from the table and stretched, her arms overhead, her shirt riding up to show her stomach. "I'm going to change. It's too warm in here."

She disappeared into the bathroom, and Cruz dealt out new hands while we waited. The music shifted to something with a slower tempo, something that made the RV feel smaller somehow, more intimate.

When Ashley came back, she was wearing a white ribbed tank top that had clearly been washed too many times and stretched out in all the wrong places, the neckline drooping low and the hem barely reaching her hips. Below that, plain black panties. Nothing else.

"Better," she announced, flopping onto the couch that ran along the wall opposite the dinette.

Cruz glanced up, then very knowingly looked back at his cards. I picked up my hand and tried to focus on the numbers and suits.

"Your turn," Cruz said to me.

I drew a card, discarded another. Ashley got up from the couch and came over to the table, standing behind Cruz and looking at his cards over his shoulder.

"That's cheating," I said.

"I'm not playing anymore," Ashley said. "I can look at whatever I want."

She leaned against Cruz's back, her arms draping over his shoulders, her chin resting on top of his head. Cruz shifted his cards so she couldn't see them as easily, but she just laughed and wrapped her arms around his neck more firmly.

"You're making it hard to play," Cruz said.

"Good," Ashley said.

She moved around to his side, and before Cruz could adjust his position, she'd climbed onto his lap, straddling him on the dinette bench seat. Her knees pressed against his thighs, her weight settling onto him in a way that made his cards tilt dangerously.

"Ashley," Cruz said, a warning in his voice.

"What?" she asked innocently. "I'm just sitting here."

"You're sitting on me."

"You're very comfortable."

I looked at my cards without really seeing them. Across the table, Ashley adjusted her position on Cruz's lap, settling more firmly, and I watched his jaw tighten.

"Your turn," I said to Cruz.

He managed to draw a card one-handed, the other hand having automatically gone to Ashley's hip to steady her. He studied his hand with concentration that seemed exaggerated given it was a casual card game.

Ashley leaned forward, her chest pressing against his, and whispered something in his ear that made his neck flush red. She pulled back with a grin, then leaned in again, this time pressing her mouth to the spot just below his ear.

"I can't concentrate," Cruz said, his voice strained.

"So give up," Ashley suggested against his skin.

"I'm not giving up."

She bit his earlobe, not hard but definitely with teeth, and I heard Cruz's sharp intake of breath. Her hands were in his hair now, tugging slightly, and her hips shifted in his lap in a way that couldn't be accidental.

"Discard," I reminded him.

Cruz tossed a card onto the pile without looking at it properly. I drew, made a set, discarded. The game continued in a parody of normalcy while Ashley did everything possible to derail it.

She moved from his ear to his neck, her mouth working against his skin with clear intent. I could see her tongue when she licked a line from his collar to his jaw. Her breathing had changed, gotten heavier, and the sounds she was making were small but unmistakable, little gasps and sighs that had nothing to do with the card game.

"Your hand is terrible," Ashley murmured to Cruz, looking at his cards. "You're going to lose."

"Thanks for the encouragement," Cruz managed.

Her hips moved again, a slow grind that made Cruz's free hand tighten on her hip, his fingers pressing into the bare skin exposed by her riding tank top. She made another sound, this one closer to a moan, and I watched a flush spread across her chest, visible in the low neckline of her shirt.

"Draw a card," I said to Cruz, my voice coming out rougher than intended.

He drew. Studied his hand with what must have been Herculean focus given what Ashley was doing to his neck. She was leaving marks now, I

could see them forming, dark spots where her mouth had been, and she seemed pleased with her work, admiring it before moving to a new spot.

Her hands tugged at his hair again, pulling his head back to expose more of his throat, and she bit down on the tendon there, making Cruz actually groan out loud.

"Sorry," he said immediately, to me, his face flushed.

"It's fine," I lied.

Ashley pulled back enough to look at him, her pupils dilated, her breathing ragged. She kissed him then, full on the mouth, her tongue visible between their lips, and his cards finally fell from his hand onto the table as both his arms went around her waist.

The kiss lasted long enough that I counted to ten in my head. Long enough that I could hear the wet sounds of it, see the movement of their mouths, watch Ashley's hips continue that slow grinding motion that made Cruz's hands slide lower, to the curve of her ass barely covered by those black panties.

When they broke apart, Ashley turned to look at me, her lips swollen and red.

"I think I win," she said.

"You're not even playing," I pointed out.

"Still winning," she said, and turned back to Cruz, kissing him again.

I gathered the cards from the table, straightening the deck and putting it back in its box with methodical attention to detail. The music had shifted to something with a heavier beat, and Ashley moved in rhythm to it, still on Cruz's lap, still kissing him between words.

"I'm tired," I announced to no one in particular.

Ashley broke away from Cruz's mouth long enough to say, "We should all go to bed."

The implication of what she meant by that hung in the air. She'd be going to bed with Cruz, in those panties and that stretched tank top, in that state of obvious arousal that her body wasn't hiding.

"Yeah," Cruz said, his voice rough. "Bedtime."

Ashley climbed off his lap with visible reluctance, and I could see the effect she'd had on him, the way his jeans sat wrong, the flush still on his neck and face. She stretched again, the tank top riding up to show more skin, and headed toward the bedroom without waiting to see if Cruz followed.

He sat at the table for another moment, taking a long drink of his beer, then stood up and cleared our empty bottles to the sink. We moved around the small space with practiced efficiency, putting away the cards and pretzels, turning off the music, preparing the RV for night.

"I'll get the dinette set up," Cruz offered.

"I've got it," I said.

We both knew what was happening. We both knew the sleeping arrangement had been decided the moment Ashley climbed onto his lap wearing next to nothing and made those sounds against his neck.

Cruz nodded and headed toward the bedroom. I heard Ashley's voice, bright and pleased, then the rustle of sheets and blankets, the creak of the mattress.

I converted the dinette with efficient, angry movements, yanking the table from its mount and throwing the cushions into position. The bedding went on roughly, and I didn't bother smoothing out the wrinkles.

From the bedroom came more sounds, conversation too low to make out words, then laughter, then something that definitely wasn't laughter.

I turned off all the lights except the small LED over the sink and lay down on the hard cushions in the darkness, listening to the ocean and trying not to listen to anything else.

The dinette cushions felt harder than ever, the gaps between them more pronounced, like the RV was actively conspiring to keep me awake. I lay on my back staring at the ceiling, at the emergency escape hatch that glowed faintly with reflected light from the campground security lamp outside.

The bedroom door had closed with a soft click maybe five minutes ago, and now music started playing, something with bass I could feel through the RV's frame. Not loud enough to be obnoxious to neighbors, but loud enough to cover other sounds. That was the point, obviously.

I turned onto my side, facing away from the bedroom, and pulled the thin blanket up to my shoulders. The ocean provided white noise through the RV's walls, waves rolling in with mechanical regularity, but it wasn't enough to drown out my awareness of what was happening twenty feet away.

Laughter came through the door, muffled but unmistakable. Ashley's voice, high and bright, then Cruz's deeper response. More laughter, then silence, then the music continuing its steady rhythm.

I shifted onto my other side, now facing toward the bedroom, and immediately regretted it. A thin line of light showed under the door, warm and yellow, and I found myself staring at it like it might reveal something through pure force of attention.

The mattress creaked. Not the settling creak of someone getting comfortable, but rhythmic, purposeful. The music swelled during a chorus, masking the sound temporarily, then fell back to verses and the creaking became audible again.

I turned onto my back once more. The ceiling offered no answers, just smooth white fiberglass that reflected the faint glow from the kitchen LED. I tried counting the rivets visible in the metal frame, lost count around thirty, started over, gave up.

A sound came through the door that the music couldn't quite cover, something between a gasp and a moan. Ashley's voice, no question. I closed my eyes and tried to think about literally anything else. The hiking trail from yesterday. The menu at that taco place. The weird noise the RV's engine had been making that Cruz thought might be the fan belt.

The mattress springs created a soundtrack I couldn't ignore. Each movement translated through the RV's frame into vibration I could feel through the dinette cushions beneath me. The music continued, something with electronic beats and a female vocalist, and under it the biological rhythm that needed no translation.

I sat up, swung my legs off the bench, and walked to the small kitchen area. The refrigerator hummed when I opened it, cool air washing out, and I grabbed a water bottle without really wanting it. I drank half of it standing there in the near darkness, the bottle cold against my palm, and tried to focus on the sensation of swallowing, of breathing, of existing in this moment doing this specific mundane thing.

Another sound from the bedroom, louder this time, less controlled. The music had hit a quieter bridge section and Ashley's voice came through clear and unmistakable, a cry that trailed into something that might have been Cruz's name.

I set the water bottle on the counter harder than necessary, the plastic making a sharp sound against the laminate. No response from the bedroom. They either hadn't heard or didn't care.

Back to the dinette. I lay down again, this time grabbing the extra pillow and putting it over my head, pressing it against my ears with both hands.

The darkness under the pillow was absolute, and the pressure created a ringing silence that helped for maybe thirty seconds.

But I could still feel the vibrations. The RV was too small, the construction too light, every movement in that bedroom transmitted through the floor and walls and frame like a telegraph system designed specifically to torture me.

I threw the pillow aside and rolled onto my stomach, pressing my face into the mattress. The cushions smelled like vinyl and the musty scent of storage, and breathing became uncomfortable quickly, so I turned my head to the side and resumed staring at nothing.

Time passed in segments I couldn't accurately measure. The music continued without pause, track flowing into track, all of them with that same driving beat. The mattress sounds varied in intensity but never fully stopped, building and subsiding in waves that seemed to last forever.

At some point I found myself counting seconds between creaks, trying to establish a pattern, then realized what I was doing and forced myself to stop. I tried breathing exercises, the kind meant for meditation, focusing on inhale and exhale. Made it through maybe six breaths before another sound broke my concentration.

My phone was in my bag somewhere, probably with headphones I could use to drown all of this out, but getting up and rummaging through luggage in the dark would make noise and I couldn't face the possibility of them hearing me, knowing I was awake and aware and unable to escape this.

So I stayed on the uncomfortable cushions and listened to the ocean and tried to pretend that was the only sound in the world. Waves rolling in, waves rolling out, the eternal rhythm of tides that existed before humans and would continue after, indifferent to everything happening in this small metal box on the edge of the continent.

The bedroom sounds built to something I couldn't ignore, a crescendo of movement and noise that the music couldn't mask, Ashley's voice rising above it all in a series of cries that were unmistakably orgasmic. Then silence, or relative silence, just the music and my own heartbeat loud in my ears.

I checked the time on the microwave clock. 11:47. I'd been lying here for over an hour.

More quiet conversation from the bedroom, words I couldn't make out but the tone was soft, intimate, the kind of post-sex murmuring that speaks

to satisfaction and closeness. The mattress creaked again, differently this time, people shifting to more comfortable positions, settling in.

The music continued for another twenty minutes, maybe longer. I'd given up tracking time, given up trying to sleep, just existed in a state of forced wakefulness, cataloging every sound and vibration while pretending I wasn't.

Then the music stopped. The sudden silence felt profound, broken only by the ocean and the normal sounds of the RV's systems. The light under the bedroom door went out, leaving just the faint glow from the kitchen LED to mark the edges of furniture and walls.

I lay perfectly still, listening for any indication of what came next. Quiet conversation, too low to understand. A laugh, soft and satisfied. More settling sounds, blankets being adjusted, pillows being arranged.

Then silence, real silence, the kind that suggested sleep or something close to it.

I finally let myself relax slightly, my muscles unclenching from a tension I hadn't fully acknowledged. The cushions beneath me remained uncomfortable, the gaps and ridges pressing into my shoulders and hips, but exhaustion was starting to override discomfort.

The ocean rolled on. The RV settled into its nighttime creaks and groans. And in the bedroom, two people slept in a bed they'd earned through a game of rock-paper-scissors, their bodies warm under covers I couldn't see, in positions I could too easily imagine.

I closed my eyes and waited for morning.

I rolled over on the dinette bench, searching for any position that might offer relief from the relentless discomfort of the plywood base and thin cushions. My shoulder ached from the pressure, and I shifted my weight, turning to face the wall that separated the living area from the bedroom.

That's when I saw it. The bedroom door stood open, not fully, but enough. Maybe six inches of gap, enough to create a clear sightline from where I lay directly to the bed.

The bedroom light was off, but ambient glow from the campground filtered through the windows, enough that my eyes, already adjusted to darkness, could make out shapes and movement with shocking clarity.

Ashley was riding Cruz, her hips against his thighs, her body moving in a rhythm that matched the muffled sounds I'd been hearing through the door. Her breasts were bare, her head thrown back, and I could see the line of her

throat, the curve of her spine, the way her hair swayed with each movement.

Cruz's hands gripped her waist, his fingers visible as they dug into her skin. His chest was heaving, his gaze focused on her face with an intensity I'd never seen from him before. When she leaned forward, her breasts pressed against his chest, and his mouth found her neck, kissing and biting with clear intent.

The sounds were unmuffled now, no music to mask them. Ashley's moans filled the space, breathy and desperate, punctuated by Cruz's deeper groans and the rhythmic sound of flesh meeting flesh. I could see the muscles in his thighs tensing with each thrust, could see the way Ashley's body trembled when he pushed particularly deep.

She changed position, lifting off him and turning around, and now I could see even more. The curve of her ass, the way Cruz's cock glistened as she lowered herself back onto him, the intensity of his expression as he watched her move. Her hands braced on his thighs, her back arched, and the angle let me see exactly where their bodies met, the explicit reality of him sliding into her with each stroke.

Cruz sat up, wrapping his arms around her waist, and his mouth found her shoulder again, kissing and biting while his hips continued their rhythm. One of his hands slid down her stomach, disappearing between her legs, and Ashley's entire body jerked at the contact, a sharp gasp escaping her lips.

"Yes," she gasped, and I heard Cruz's responding grunt, felt the tempo increase as his thrusts became harder, faster, more desperate.

Ashley's moans were constant now, building in pitch and intensity, and I watched her body convulse, watched her hands tighten on Cruz's thighs, watched her mouth open in a silent cry before sound finally emerged, my name or his name or no name at all, just pure release that made her entire body shudder.

Cruz followed seconds later, his cock buried deep, his chest pressed against her back, his own groan muffled against her shoulder as his hips finally stilled.

They stayed like that for a moment, both breathing hard, still connected, sweat visible on their skin in the dim light. Then Ashley slowly climbed off him, and I saw everything, the wetness, the evidence of what they'd done, Cruz's cock still hard as she moved away.

She stood up from the bed, completely naked, her body silhouetted in the window light, and started walking toward the bedroom door.

Toward the bathroom.

Toward me.

I rolled over instantly, forcing my body into what I hoped was a natural sleeping position, face toward the wall, one arm under the pillow, legs slightly bent. I closed my eyes and concentrated on keeping my breathing slow and even, the deep rhythm of genuine sleep.

Her footsteps were soft on the vinyl flooring, nearly silent, but I tracked each one by sound and vibration. She paused in the bedroom doorway. I could feel her presence there, could sense her looking out into the main cabin, could imagine her eyes adjusting to the darkness and finding my form on the dinette bench.

The silence stretched. I kept my breathing steady, measured, fighting the urge to swallow or shift position or do any of the hundred things a conscious body wants to do. My heart hammered in my chest, and I prayed she couldn't see it, couldn't detect the tension in my supposedly sleeping form.

She was trying to determine if the door had been open long enough for me to see. Trying to decide if I was really asleep or faking. The pause felt endless, each second marked by my controlled breaths and the distant ocean waves.

Finally, she moved. Her footsteps continued toward the bathroom, and I heard the door close softly, heard the fan click on, heard water running in the sink.

I stayed frozen in my sleeping position, not daring to move, barely daring to breathe. The toilet flushed. More water running. The bathroom door opened, and her footsteps returned, passing the dinette bench where I lay with my eyes closed and my breathing carefully regulated.

She paused again. Right next to me this time, close enough that I could smell her, sweat and sex and something else, close enough that I could feel the heat radiating from her naked body.

"Reid?" she whispered, so quiet it was almost inaudible.

I didn't respond. Didn't move. Maintained the fiction of deep sleep with every ounce of control I possessed.

Another pause, then her footsteps continued toward the bedroom. I heard her climb back onto the bed, heard Cruz's voice asking something I couldn't

make out, heard her response equally muffled.

Then the bedroom door closed with a firm click, the kind of conscious closure that said she was making sure it wouldn't swing open again.

I opened my eyes in the darkness and stared at the wall six inches from my face. My breathing was still controlled, still measured, but now it was to keep myself from hyperventilating rather than to fake sleep.

The images were burned into my vision, appearing every time I blinked. Ashley's body moving on top of Cruz. The explicit reality of their coupling, the sounds they made, the way they looked at each other, the undeniable evidence that what had started as a joke had become something else entirely.

I lay on the uncomfortable cushions and listened to quiet conversation from the bedroom, too low to understand but the tone unmistakable. Intimate. Satisfied. The conversation of two people who'd just fucked each other and were comfortable in the aftermath.

The ocean provided its constant soundtrack. The RV creaked and settled around me. And I remained motionless on the dinette bench, pretending to be asleep, pretending I hadn't seen anything, pretending this was still somehow a game we were all playing together.

The bedroom went quiet. The light that had been visible under the door earlier stayed off. Time passed in increments I didn't measure, and eventually my body's exhaustion overrode everything else.

I closed my eyes and waited for morning, knowing that when it came, we'd all pretend last night had been different than it was.

The morning light came through the RV's windows at an angle that suggested I'd slept later than intended, though sleep was a generous term for the fitful unconsciousness I'd eventually achieved. I woke with my neck kinked from the awkward position on the dinette cushions, my shoulder numb from pressure against the plywood base.

The RV was silent in a way that felt willful, the kind of quiet that happens when people are awake but avoiding interaction. I sat up slowly, working feeling back into my shoulder, and looked toward the bedroom. The door was closed, no light visible underneath, no sound coming from within.

I converted the dinette back to its daytime configuration with movements I tried to keep quiet, mounting the table and arranging the cushions, folding the bedding and stowing it in the overhead compartment. Each action felt

louder than it should, the click of the table locking into place, the rustle of fabric, my own breathing.

The coffee maker sat ready from last night, and I filled the reservoir with water from the jug, the liquid splashing into the tank with what seemed like excessive volume. I pressed the button and the machine began its grinding, burbling process, filling the RV with the smell of brewing coffee and mechanical noise that at least broke the oppressive silence.

I stood at the small counter waiting for the pot to fill, staring out the window at the campground coming to life around us. A family two sites over loaded bikes onto a rack. An older couple walked past with a small dog on a leash. Normal people doing normal vacation activities, completely unaware of whatever had happened in this particular RV.

The coffee maker beeped completion, and I poured a cup, added cream from the fridge, stood there holding it without drinking. The bedroom door remained closed. I checked my phone for the time, eight forty-three, and for lack of anything better to do, opened the weather app and studied the forecast for the next three days like it mattered.

I drank my coffee in small sips, making it last, and when the cup was empty I rinsed it in the sink with more attention than necessary, dried it with a dish towel, put it away in the cabinet. The bedroom door stayed closed.

Finally I gave up on waiting and got dressed in the tiny bathroom, brushing my teeth and washing my face and running wet hands through my hair to make it lie flat. When I emerged, the bedroom door was still closed, and I stood in the main cabin for a moment feeling ridiculous, a guest in a space I'd helped pay for, waiting for permission to exist.

I grabbed the keys and went to the driver's seat, settling in behind the wheel and adjusting the mirrors though they were already properly positioned. The steering wheel was cool under my hands, the vinyl seats unchanged from yesterday, everything exactly as it had been except for whatever had fundamentally shifted in the past twelve hours.

From the bedroom came a sound, muffled laughter, Ashley's voice bright with amusement. A lower response from Cruz, then more laughter, then silence.

I looked at my phone again. Eight fifty-six. How long did it take to get dressed? I drummed my fingers on the steering wheel, stopped when I noticed I was doing it, crossed my arms instead, then uncrossed them and rested my hands in my lap.

Nine oh-four. More silence from the bedroom. I started the engine just to have something to do, let it warm up, watched the temperature gauge slowly climb toward operating range. The RPMs settled into idle rhythm, the whole RV vibrating with the engine's rumble.

Nine twelve. I turned the engine off. The silence felt worse now in contrast.

Finally, at nine seventeen, the bedroom door opened. Cruz emerged first, wearing jeans and a t-shirt, his hair damp like he'd showered in the tiny RV bathroom at some point when I wasn't paying attention. He nodded at me, a gesture that conveyed nothing, and headed to the kitchen area to pour his own coffee.

Then Ashley appeared in the bedroom doorway, and I felt my grip tighten on the steering wheel.

She wore a cropped white tank top that showed her midriff, the fabric thin enough that I could see she wasn't wearing a bra underneath. Her shorts were denim, cut-offs that barely covered anything, frayed edges riding high on her thighs. Her legs looked impossibly long in white sneakers with ankle socks that had little pom-poms at the heels.

But it was more than the clothes. Her hair fell in perfect beach waves past her shoulders, the kind of styling that required time and product and attention. Her makeup was flawless, subtle but planned, mascara that made her eyes huge, some kind of bronzer or blush that made her skin glow, lips glossed to a shine that caught the light.

She looked like she was going to a photoshoot, not continuing a camping trip. She looked like someone who'd spent the morning being thoroughly satisfied and wanted everyone to know it.

She moved through the RV with energy that seemed excessive for the hour and circumstances, practically bouncing on her feet as she grabbed a water bottle from the fridge. She came to the passenger seat and dropped into it with the unselfconscious grace of someone completely comfortable in their body, completely unconcerned with how much skin was showing or how the crop top rode up when she settled into the seat.

"So," she said, turning to face me with a smile that was pure sunshine and zero acknowledgment of anything that had happened in the past twenty-four hours. "I was thinking we should hit that lighthouse I saw on the map yesterday. It's supposed to have incredible views from the top, and there's a beach right next to it where we could hang out for a while."

She pulled her seatbelt across her body, the strap bisecting her chest in a way that was impossible not to notice, and adjusted the air conditioning vent to blow directly on her face.

"The one about an hour north?" I asked, my voice coming out more normal than I expected.

"That's the one," she said, pulling out her phone and scrolling through photos she'd saved. "Look how pretty it is."

She leaned toward me to show the screen, close enough that I could smell her shampoo and something else, perfume maybe, something I didn't recognize from the rest of the trip. Her skin had that particular glow that came from recent exertion and satisfaction, and when she smiled at the photo on her screen, I could see the happiness radiating from her like heat.

Cruz appeared with his coffee and climbed into the back, settling onto the couch without comment. Ashley twisted in her seat to look at him.

"You good with the lighthouse?" she asked.

"Sure," Cruz said.

"Perfect," Ashley said, turning back to face forward. She put her bare feet up on the dashboard, crossing her ankles, completely at ease. "Let's go then."

I put the RV in gear and pulled out of the campsite, navigating the narrow roads of the campground toward the exit. Ashley hummed along to a song playing quietly from her phone, scrolling through more photos, planning more stops, acting for all the world like this was day one of the trip instead of the aftermath of whatever line we'd crossed last night.